

Look, watch, hear, and listen

Teaching guide

Describe attention and perception.

Understand the distinction

Look at directs visual attention toward something. Watch usually involves attention over time, often to something changing or moving. Hear describes receiving sound; listen emphasizes paying attention to it.

Use to before the object of listen: listen to music. Hear does not need to before its object. The attention distinction is useful but not absolute: hear a speaker can also mean attend a talk. Learn familiar activity phrases such as watch television and look at a photo.

Compare the patterns

DIRECT ATTENTION

Look at this photo.

Turn your attention to it.

OVER TIME

We watched the match.

Follow an event as it develops.

SOUND

I heard music and stopped to listen to it.

The sound was perceived, then attended to.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: Please listen ___ the announcement.

2. Choose for a moving event: We ___ the game.

3. Correct this: I heard to a loud noise.

Use it in your own life

Describe a sound you noticed and what you then paid attention to.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. to

Listen takes to before the object.

2. watched

Watch is natural for following a game.

3. I heard a loud noise.

Hear takes the object directly.

One possible response

I heard a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-39.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe a sound you noticed and what you then paid attention to.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.